03

Nine voices around one table

Ask why the pilot never scaled and every executive gives a sincere, accurate answer — from where they sit.

CEO
Nine sensible people moving toward an outcome that serves no one

CFO
Licences signed before value is proven

COO
An operation that cannot pause for a transformation

CIO
Shadow AI and agents without owners

HR
A fear of replacement no communication plan reaches

SALES & MARKETING
Promises a fragmented organisation cannot keep

PROCUREMENT
Lock-in signed before value

SUPPLY CHAIN
Buffers removed from a forecast nobody trusts

BUSINESS UNITS
Best people absorbed, benefits claimed centrally

Each explanation is locally true — so each fix is only partly effective. Finance tightens funding and pilots slow; IT tightens governance and shadow AI goes underground. HR launches engagement and the fear stays, because fear was never the root.

The root cause: incoherence

The root cause is not AI, data, culture or leadership. It is **incoherence**: the parts of the enterprise each work reasonably well, but the connections between them — decisions, handovers, priorities, information — no longer form a working whole.

Decisions keep waiting

Many people are involved; no one owns the trade-off.

Work keeps changing hands

Every department does its part; the shared outcome stays out of reach.

Priorities keep competing

Everything is priority one, so nothing is.

None of this was created by AI. It accumulated over decades of local fixes — governance added after incidents, systems bought per department, reorganisations that moved boxes but not decision rights. Each layer solved a local problem; together they built an enterprise too complex to change quickly.

EXECUTIVE INSIGHT · THE TEN-MINUTE TEST

Which decision has been open longer than a month, and who owns it? Which outcome passes through so many hands that no one owns it? How often do the same five names appear across your initiatives? **Two uncomfortable answers mean the pilot was never your bottleneck. The system was.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Incoherence lives between the parts, not inside them.
- ✔ Three signals reveal it: waiting decisions, travelling work, competing priorities.
- ✔ It predates AI by decades; AI only makes it visible.